Since it is you, highly honored Herr Professor, whom my son seems to admire and esteem more than any other scholar currently active in physics, it is you to whom I have taken the liberty of turning with the humble request to read his paper published in the Annalen für Physick and to write him, if possible, a few words of encouragement, so that he might recover his joy in living and working.

If, in addition, you could secure him an Assistent's position for now or the next autumn, my gratitude would know no bounds.

I beg you once again to forgive me for my impudence in writing to you, and I am also taking the liberty of mentioning that my son does not know anything about my unusual step.

I remain, highly esteemed Herr Professor, your devoted

Hermann Einstein

It was, indeed, a period of depression for Albert Einstein. He had been jobless for eight months, since graduating from the Zurich Politechnikum at age twenty-one, and he felt himself a failure.

At the Politechnikum (usually called the "ETH" after its German-language initials), Einstein had studied under several of the world's most renowned physicists and mathematicians, but had not got on well with them. In the turn-of-the-century academic world where most Professors (with a capital P) demanded and expected respect, Einstein gave little. Since childhood he had bristled against authority, always questioning, never accepting anything without testing its truth himself. "Unthinking respect for authority is the greatest enemy of truth," he asserted. Heinrich Weber, the most famous of his two ETH physics professors, complained in exasperation: "You are a smart boy, Einstein, a very smart boy. But you have one great fault: you do not let yourself be told anything." His other physics professor, Jean Pernet, asked him why he didn't study medicine, law, or philology rather than physics. "You can do what you like," Pernet said, "1 only wish to warn you in your own interest."

Einstein did not make matters better by his casual attitude toward coursework. "One had to cram all this stuff into one's mind for the examinations whether one liked it or not," he later said. His mathematics professor, Hermann Minkowski, of whom we shall hear much in Chapter 2, was so put off by Einstein's attitude that he called him a "lazy dog."